and I feel myself melting into my surroundings, caught between a realisation of deep physical exhaustion and a profound stubbornness to carry on the job. Cooky walks up to me while I'm cowering in the corner. He doesn't even ask. I just nod. I think to myself – one last push.

Deep breath. Five seconds in. Five seconds out. Isolate the emotion. Assassin mode now. Bowl the ball I need to. I bowl an off-cutter to Haddin, trying to vary the speed of the balls he is receiving since he is seeing it so well. He swings and misses, the ball going straight through to Prior. I hear nothing, but the slip cordon all jump around celebrating. Aleem Dar has heard nothing either and given it not out. I haven't even had a conversation before Cooky has reviewed it. He has heard a noise. Haddin then walks up to me, saying he thinks he's nicked it. *You think you've what?* He nods, in concession. Then there is the big screen, the tiniest of hot spots, the crowd roar, the overturning of the decision and I am running off into the distance, my whole team following me, a classic Ashes match won.

I sit in my spot in the corner by the balcony in the dressing room. I don't want to get up, I just want to sleep. I am mentally and physically drained, overwhelmed with relief. It has hit me quite hard to have been so high, so tense for five days, so full of adrenaline, and now my body is charged with feeling it all. Then I think to myself, *Wow, the ball wasn't swinging, yet I found a way*. I have taken ten wickets in one ball short of 56 overs. I'm told, just before I fall asleep in a dressing room full of people, cap over my eyes, that I've just overtaken Fred Trueman in the all-time wicket takers' list. *It would be nice to chalk that off on Darren Gough's bag*, I think as the lights close in.